



Black Women's Cambridge

A Case Study on Critical GIS and Black Feminist Geographies

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Abstract

Black feminist geographies explain how Black women's intersectional bodily and emotional experiences of race and gender are expressed in and reinforced by landscapes. They also **challenge traditional geographic practices** that treat one dominant perspective as an objective truth. Though previous work explores how feminist geographies be used in **geographic information systems (GIS)** to create more critical, subjective geographic representations, this work often fails to includes intersectionality. In this study, we use a **research-through-design** methodology to locate and **visualize Black women's geographies in ArcGIS**, extending previous arguments in feminist GIS to highlight Black feminist geographies and examine their disruptive potential in traditional GIS visualization.

How might visualizing Black women's geographies disrupt traditional GIS practices?

Introduction

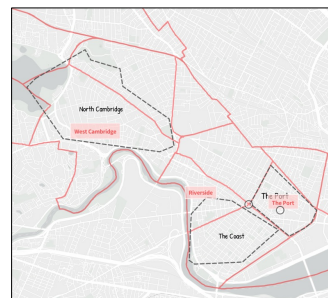
Black women's sense of place is expressed both under constraints of and in resistance to intersectional oppression, creating an ambiguous, subjective experience of geography rooted in their embodied and affective relationships with space. "Feminist [and Black] geographers challenge objectivity and mind/body dualisms [of GIS] by recognizing emotion and embodiment as ways of knowing," emphasizing qualitative data, and rejecting simplification and quantification native to GIS features. Though work has been done to center both Black and feminist geographic perspectives and approaches to GIS, it is often consolidated under the label of 'critical GIS' and continues to neglect intersectionality.

***	Race and Race Relations
***	Local Pride and Identity
***	Displacement and Mourning Old Cambridge

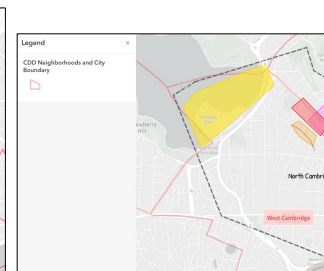
Layers and effects to represent emotional complexity: Map layers can reveal, hide, and overlay these emotions to convey the complexity of these women's experiences.

Results

GIS as a Black feminist tool



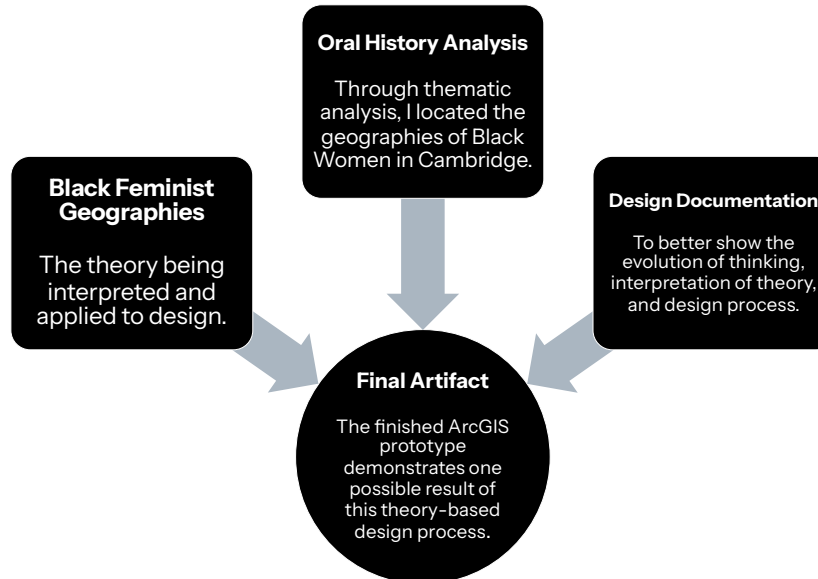
Self Identification: Neighborhoods were named and defined differently by these Black women than by the city. Drawing on features and custom labels can reflect this self-identification practice.



Minimal Disruptive Potential: These systems exclude the visualization, dissemination, and comprehension of subaltern geographies

Methods

Design as a Mode of Inquiry



Conclusion

Implications

- **Cultural Memory in Cambridge:** These mapping the embodied and emotional geographies of Black Cantabrigian women offers unique insights on how the continued development of the city directly impacts.
- **Critical GIS:** This work corroborates previous findings in critical GIS that identify limitations of other software in visualizing embodied geographies and specifically explores these limitations as they apply to Black women's geographies.

Future Work

- **Larger Scale/Extent:** Examining Black Women's geographies across multiple cities or diasporic perspectives, or with a larger corpus of oral histories offers more variation and depth of knowledge
- **Participatory Approach:** Semi-structured interviews specifically about Black women's geographic perspectives and/or community mapping projects provide situated knowledge from primary sources

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